

FamilyNest

The Build

From initial commit to a private family memory app with a real gift purchase flow.

Feb 5

First commit

May 16

This snapshot

132

PRs merged

691

Total commits

What you're reading

Three months of work, told as a story. Five phases, from the first stubbed family-member card to a live buyer-pays-then-recipient-redeems Stripe gift flow. Each phase ends with what shipped, what the inflection point was, and where the next phase picked up.

How to read it

Cover to cover takes about ten minutes. The phase headers tell you the date range and the headline. The PR lists under each are the real artifacts — every one is a merged pull request you can find on GitHub if you want to dig in. The final pages capture strategic decisions that shaped the build and the things still open.

Five phases in three months

Phase 1 • Foundations • Feb 5 – Mar 1

First commit. Auth wired up. Member cards designed and redesigned. A privacy audit closes 9 findings before the project has a hundred users. The product takes its name, “Family Nest,” and the first family invite emails go out.

Phase 2 • Core features • Mar 8 – Mar 13

Bucket lists. Voice memos with optional photo. The first plan tiers (free / paid). A storage-bucket hardening to close a CDN bypass. Speed work — parallel uploads, image compression — when uploads start choking on phones. The first comprehensive audit-fix day (privacy, billing, data integrity, performance — four PRs landed the same Friday).

Phase 3 • Feature Catalog • Mar 14 – Mar 28

The architectural pivot. Instead of bolting features onto a flat nav, introduce a Feature Catalog: every feature is opt-in per family. The dashboard gets themes. The pricing model gets a monthly tier and a Mother's Day founding rate. By the end of the phase, fifteen new features (Reunion Planner, MLB Stadium Tour, Baby Book, Quotes, Awards Night, Game Night, Garden, Volunteer, Films, Homes, Teams, Family Book Club, Gratitude Board, Family Motto, Stories) have shipped behind the catalog.

Phase 4 • Tight family pivot • Mar 29 – Apr 12

Audience explicitly reframed from “multi-generational” to “tight family.” A new Letters feature lets parents write to kids. The homepage gets a complete copy rewrite. A Mother's Day campaign goes out — Legacy founding rate at \$249. Legal docs, security hardening (S15, S16, C6), and a UX flow audit (UX1–UX12) close out the pre-launch hardening pass.

Phase 5 • Quality review & gift flow • Apr 23 – May 16

The most recent session. A real walkthrough of familynest.io as a user. Eighteen PRs to simplify the landing and dashboard. A billing/plan re-audit comes back clean. A full buyer-pays-then-recipient-redeems gift purchase flow gets designed, built, and shipped across four phases. The product now sells gifts as gifts — not as “wrap a login on a card.”

PHASE 1

Foundations

February 5 – March 1, 2026

The product is born. Rob commits the initial code base on a Thursday afternoon — a Next.js scaffold with Supabase auth, basic middleware, and the bones of a family-members system. Within two days the public landing page is up and the first sign-up completes. Most of this phase is foundations work that doesn't ship through pull requests — direct main commits, the messy way things start.

The phase ends with the first formal Privacy Hardening audit: nine findings (2 critical, 4 high, 3 medium) fixed in a single PR before the project has any real user volume. Setting a pattern that holds for the rest of the build — audit, fix, ship.

What shipped

- #2 Redesign member cards and fix pending invitation logic
- #3 Rename 'Our Family Nest' to 'Family Nest' sitewide
- #4 Redesign member cards with portrait layout
- #6 Fix: Add Member form opens as modal instead of pushing content down
- #7 Privacy hardening: 9 audit findings fixed (CRIT-2, HIGH-1/3/4/5, MED-1/3/6, CRIT-1)
- #8 Fix invited user signup creating spurious 'Our Family' family

Inflection point

The Feb 21 product rename from "Our Family Nest" to "Family Nest" — small change, big signal. The product stops being a Thompson-family-specific thing and becomes a platform anyone can use. The naming choice ripples forward: the URL, the email templates, the marketing voice all settle.

PHASE 2

Core features

March 8 – March 13, 2026

Six days, twenty-seven merged PRs. The product goes from “a way to add family members” to “an app you can actually use.” A Friday push lands the first Plan Tiers, Bucket Lists, the comms-pipeline fix (emails were silently failing), and a security hardening that closes a CDN bypass on storage buckets. Voice Memos get optional photo attachments. The mobile experience gets its first dedicated fix pass after photo uploads start crashing on iPhone.

March 13 is the first formal audit-fixing day — four PRs land within hours of each other: privacy, billing, data integrity, performance v2. This pattern becomes the model for the rest of the build.

Key features added

- #10 Add Family Bucket List
- #11 fix(comms): resolve zero-email pipeline + add 4 missing touchpoints
- #14 security: harden storage buckets — close CDN bypass
- #16 feat(tiers): redesign plan limits, enforcement and pricing page
- #18 feat(voice-memos): add optional photo attachment
- #23 UX: photo-first voice memo flow
- #24 SEO: Blog, OG image, and keyword meta title

Speed & mobile push (Mar 9–11)

- #25 Fix pet photo upload timeout
- #27 Parallelize file uploads for faster saving
- #28 Speed optimizations: compression, progress, parallel queries
- #29 Fix mobile crash when uploading photos

Big upgrades (Mar 11–12)

- #31 Landing page CRO: gift-forward copy & persona section
First major investment in conversion-focused landing copy
- #33 Journal enhancements: 20 photos, 5 videos, cover photo, card/grid views, person filter
- #34 Add Meta Pixel tracking for Facebook ads
- #41 Free tier: unlock all features with low instance limits
Switch from feature-gated free tier to limit-gated

#42 Data entry UX: voice dictation, quick capture, photo captions

#44 Add 'remembered' members for those we hold in our hearts

First audit-fixing day (Mar 13)

#49 Privacy audit: add family scoping, rate limiting, reduce signed URL

#50 Billing audit fixes: plan gates, storage tracking, family scoping

#51 Data integrity fixes v2: storage cleanup, upload rollback, FK on-delete

#52 Performance fixes v2: batch imports, memoize map, limit queries

Inflection point

PR #41 — switching the free tier from “some features locked” to “all features, low limits.” That design decision shapes everything downstream: the Feature Catalog (Phase 3) only works because Free isn't gated on feature access, just usage volume.

PHASE 3

Feature Catalog & expansion

March 14 – March 28, 2026

The architectural pivot that defines the product. Until now, every feature has been bolted onto a flat nav. Adding a feature meant adding a nav item — fine for five features, untenable at fifteen.

PR #59–60 introduce the Feature Catalog: every non-core feature is opt-in per family via a settings page. The nav becomes dynamic. Suddenly the product can ship niche features (MLB Stadium Tour, Garden Log, Awards Night) without overwhelming every user. By the end of the phase, fifteen new features ship behind the catalog without making the nav feel bloated.

The catalog itself (Mar 18–19)

- #58 Add Tools section with Reunion Planner
- #59 Privacy copy, journal photos, and Feature Catalog system
- #60 Feature Catalog: 6 new add-on features + nav overhaul
- The architectural pivot itself
- #61 MLB Stadium Tour + fully dynamic nav system
- #62 Dashboard overhaul: themes, stats, plan badges, account deletion, landing page

Pricing overhaul (Mar 20)

- #64 Pricing overhaul: monthly billing, founding rate, unlimited free, 20 GB annual
- #65 Pricing overhaul: monthly plan, founding rate, billing fixes, docs refresh
- #69 Add Baby Book feature + marketing copy updates

Multi-nest hardening (Mar 21)

- #78 Add family_id to share photo insert + multi-nest audit
- #79 Multi-nest hardening: explicit family checks
- #82 Rich weekly family digest email

Catalog expansion (Mar 25–27)

- #86 Feature catalog: new categories + 7 features + Favourites filter fix
- #87 Add Family Book Club and Family Challenges
- #88 Family Motto, Gratitude Board, Ancestry Stories + catalog previews
- #89 Batch: Security fixes, Annual Events, Time Capsule privacy, Nav redesign

#90 Add Family Media positioning across homepage

Brand line “Family Media. Not Social Media.” ships

#91 Security & Privacy: IDOR fixes + signed URL hardening

#92 Add Our Teams feature

#93 Redesign Favourites: user-defined custom lists

#94 Add 8 new features: Quotes, Predictions, Awards Night, Homes, Films, Game Night, Volunteer, Garden

Inflection point

PR #60 — the Feature Catalog. Without it, the product would have either capped at ~10 features or become unusable. With it, every family curates their own Nest, the nav stays lean by default, and shipping new features stops being a nav-redesign exercise. Every feature added since lives behind this system.

PHASE 4

Tight family pivot & launch prep

March 29 – April 12, 2026

After three weeks of building broadly, the audience gets a deliberate narrowing. The pitch reorients around tight families — the people who actually use the product day-to-day — and away from multi-generational framing. The Letters feature ships specifically for this audience: parent-to-kid letters sealed for later.

Mother's Day becomes the de facto launch moment. The Legacy plan gets a \$249 founding rate (down from \$349) with a countdown to May 10. Two homepage rewrites land in the same week. The drip email sequence gets reworked to match the new tight-family voice.

The phase ends with the most thorough pre-launch hardening pass of the build — UX flow audit (UX1–UX12), legal docs, password reset fixes, member deletion safety, onboarding improvements, and a security pass closing S15, S16, and C6.

Audience reframe (Mar 29–30)

- #95 Add Family Contacts — share outside the nest without giving app access
- #96 Tight family retrofit: Letters feature + copy reframe
Pivot from multi-gen to tight-family framing
- #98 Homepage tight family rewrite + in-app onboarding overhaul
- #99 Voice memos copy + Our Story rewrite
- #100 Mother's Day pricing: Legacy founding rate + storage reductions
- #101 Fix drip email copy: tight family narrative + correct pricing
- #102 Homepage copy pass: narrative, pricing, testimonials

More features (Mar 31)

- #103 Baby Book: month-by-month with age-matched prompts
- #104 Add birthday to Family Contacts + auto-sync to events
- #105 Remove Messages, add Tradition event type

Pre-launch hardening (Apr 5–12)

- #106 Fix audit items 1-4: photos, timeline filter, dev badge, voice memo
- #107 Legal docs update + security hardening (S15, S16, C6)
- #108 Onboarding improvements: clickable prompts, photo step, resend confirmation
- #110 Delete confirmations, member deletion safety, and birthday event cleanup

#111 Fix password reset + all critical UX flow issues (UX1–UX12)

#112 Onboarding improvements, delete confirmations, dependency updates + DB indexes

Inflection point

PR #96 — the tight family pivot. Until this point the product is trying to be everything to everyone: nuclear family, multi-gen family, grandparent gifters, parents with infants. After this PR the messaging narrows. The marketing copy gets sharper, the onboarding gets faster, and a feature (Letters) ships specifically for the chosen audience. The narrowing carries into Phase 5 explicitly.

PHASE 5

Quality review & gift purchase flow

April 23 – May 16, 2026

The most recent session. Eighteen PRs and three architectural shifts. It starts with a no-holds-barred walkthrough of familynest.io as a real visitor — landing first, then signed-in dashboard. The findings drive ten consecutive simplification PRs: phone-first hero, killed widgets, unified CTAs, grouped nav, default seed reduced from ten features to three.

Mid-phase, an audience confirmation: nuclear families, not extended. The pivot from Phase 4 gets explicitly locked in via memory notes. The gift-givers persona is retained as the exception — and the result is a real buyer-pays-then-recipient-redeems gift purchase flow built in four phases (PR 128 → 131).

A billing/plan enforcement re-audit comes back clean. The migration workflow gets documented honestly (CI doesn't auto-apply — never has). And the phase wraps with a session handoff doc and this PDF, so the next session can pick up cold.

Site simplification (Apr 23–29)

- #113 Landing: simplify hero + features, unify CTAs, mobile-first
- #114 Dashboard: kill Weekly Streak, remove intrusive popover, polish
- #116 Memories: remove One Line A Day, demote Letters to opt-in
- #117 Fix: journal_perspectives column — author_id → family_member_id
Pre-existing 400 query silently failing for months
- #118 Fix: journal entry page crash — bind server action instead of inline arrow
- #119 Nav reorg: grouped sections, honest categories, pricing copy
- #120 Home: collapse 4 widgets into one Serendipity card
- #121 Defaults: trim new-family seed from 10 features to 3
- #122 Onboarding: lead with capture, soften the tone
- #123 Defer the WelcomeModal: theme is opt-in, not a gatekeeper
- #124 ActivityFeed empty state: align with onboarding tone
- #125 Gift flow: tighten copy, drop oversold claim, add gift-aware signup banner

Infrastructure & audits (May 5)

- #126 Migrations: document actual workflow + add pre-merge guard
- #127 Billing re-audit: no new findings, no regressions

Gift purchase flow (May 7–13)

- #128 Phase A: design doc + pending_gifts migration
 - #129 Phase B: buyer form + Stripe gift checkout
 - #130 Phase C: webhook handler + recipient/buyer emails
 - #131 Phase D: recipient redemption page + claim API
- End-to-end gift flow live in production
- #133 Add gift welcome banner for new recipients
 - #134 Fix LCP: eager-load first activity feed image

Inflection point

PR #128–131 — the four-phase gift flow. Until now, gifting was a workaround: buy Legacy yourself, configure the Nest, and physically hand over your own login credentials. After these four PRs, gifting is a first-class purchase flow: buyer pays as a guest, recipient gets an email, recipient redeems and owns the Nest from day one. The marketing claim (“the gift the whole family keeps”) finally matches the actual product mechanic.

Inflection points in chronological order

Feb 21 · The product gets its name

Renamed from “Our Family Nest” to “Family Nest.” The product stops being a Thompson-family thing and becomes a platform.

Mar 12 · Free tier model flip

Free tier switches from feature-gated to volume-gated. All features available, just with low usage caps. Without this, the Feature Catalog (Phase 3) wouldn't work.

Mar 18 · Feature Catalog architecture

Every non-core feature becomes opt-in per family. Unlocks shipping niche features without bloating the default nav.

Mar 20 · Mother's Day pricing campaign

Legacy gets a founding rate at \$249 (from \$349) with a Mother's Day countdown. The plan structure crystallizes: Free / Full Nest \$6.99/mo / Legacy \$249–\$349 one-time.

Mar 26 · “Family Media. Not Social Media.”

The positioning line ships across the homepage. Becomes the north star for every UX decision after — anything that feels like a streak or engagement mechanic gets cut.

Mar 29 · Tight family pivot

Audience narrowed from multi-generational to tight family. Triggers a homepage rewrite, the Letters feature, and the drip email rewrite. Carries into Phase 5 explicitly.

Apr 23 · Cold site quality review

User asks for an honest walkthrough of familynest.io. Triggers eighteen consecutive simplification PRs. The dashboard goes from five-dropdown / twenty-nine-item nav to four-dropdown / grouped / honest categories. Brand alignment (“not social media”) finally has implementation backing it up.

May 7 · Gift flow built right

The four-phase gift purchase flow replaces the “wrap your own login on a card” workaround with a real buyer-pays-then-recipient-redeems mechanic. The marketing claim finally matches the product.

RIGHT NOW

Where the build stands today

3

Plan tiers

30+

Add-on features

150+

Migrations applied

Audit-driven

Test coverage

The product as it sits

A private Next.js + Supabase app for tight nuclear families. Three pricing tiers (Free / Full Nest monthly / Legacy one-time). A core nav of Home / Family / Memories / Activities with grouped section headers, plus thirty-plus opt-in features via Feature Catalog. A real gift purchase flow that issues a redemption token, emails the recipient, and creates their account on redemption with the Legacy plan applied from day one.

What just shipped (May 16)

Session handoff doc and this PDF, so the next session has everything it needs to pick up cold without re-reading the whole chat. The gift flow is live but has not yet been tested with a real Stripe payment.

Top of mind for the next session

- **Real-money gift flow test** — buyer pays \$249, verifies all three emails arrive, walks the recipient redemption, refunds via Stripe dashboard. Top priority.
- **Phase E polish** — printable gift card (with print-specific CSS). The dashboard gift welcome banner is already shipped (PR 133).
- **Parked backlog** — performance pass, /blog and /contact page audits, KPI/analytics for the UX changes from Phase 5, G7 (long-standing client-side upload pre-gating in 5 modules), and a future re-enable of CI migration auto-application (4–6 hr reconciliation project).

Cold-start guide

Read `docs/SESSION_HANDOFF.md` first. It's the canonical single page that captures the gotchas, locked decisions, and files-to-know-about. This PDF is for the human; the markdown is for the model.

When the next session starts, the expected opening line is:

Suggested opening

"Did the real-money gift flow test happen? If yes — what worked, what didn't? If no — let me know if you want to walk through it, or pick from the parked backlog."

Files to know about

`docs/SESSION_HANDOFF.md` — cold-start handoff doc.

`docs/GIFT_FLOW_DESIGN.md` — gift flow architecture.

`docs/BILLING_FINDINGS.md` — canonical billing audit log.

`docs/BILLING_AUDIT_2026-05-05.md` — most recent audit snapshot.

`scripts/check-pending-migrations.sh` — pre-merge SQL guard.

`scripts/build_timeline_pdf.py` — this PDF generator (rerun to refresh).

`memory/project_target_audience.md` — audience pivot note.

`CLAUDE.md` — the Database Migrations section has the canonical workflow.